The regime considered this humanitarian disaster to be a serious security threat. The potential for social unrest and the breakdown of order was very critical. The fear of international relief workers fermenting further unrest and revolution was a concern for the regime. Reestablishing order and stability was the top priority for the government. The threat of Western soldiers establishing a presence in Myanmar was considered unacceptable. The public statement of the French Foreign Minister Bernard Kouchner calling for the use of the UN Security Council to authorize military intervention to secure access for relief aid under the principle of "responsibility to protect" created significant alarm in Naypyidaw. In addition, during a White House briefing, First Lady Laura Bush launched an attack on the regime for failing to warn the population beforehand or to take a more aggressive stance in helping with aid and assistance. She also called on neighboring countries to influence political change in Myanmar.

Many international observers believe that the dysfunctional nature of the regime played into the inability to take action. The response of the regime parallels how the North Korean government dealt with the famine a decade earlier. Myanmar authorities lacked the experience and technological know-how to deal with the relief efforts. Power outages, lack of computer access, and general bureaucratic inefficiency were all occurring in Myanmar.

Critics of the Myanmar policy argued that the cost of disengagement is too severe to overlook. The country is left more vulnerable to future disasters because of the lack of assistance from international donors. Furthermore, not only are they more vulnerable to the initial shock, but they also have less capacity to cope with the aftermath. Western policies limit aid to just a few dollars per capita, which is considerably less than the average for less developed countries. These criticisms state that the West has sacrificed opportunities to promote economic reform and empower local communities by taking a hard-line stance against the junta.

The government's lack of experience in dealing with foreign aid workers and the lack of trust on the part of the regime made a very difficult situation much worse. The ambitious push by Western aid organizations may have alienated the regime, which already felt hesitant about letting perceived enemies of the state access to the stricken areas.